

The Innovations of Vijayanagar at Hampi

(c. 1336–1565 CE)

Like many children of my generation, I too had read illustrated stories of the great king of Vijayanagar, Krishnadevaraya, and his clever adviser, Tenali Raman (south Indian counterparts to Akbar and Birbal). In one episode, Raman detects thieves inside his house and fools them into ‘overhearing’ that his treasure lies in a trunk in his well. The thieves go looking for it and end up extracting water all night only to nourish his fields. In these stories, Raman, using his peerless wit and ingenuity, outsmarts the crooks and saves the day, while also imparting practical wisdom. I loved these stories, though ‘woke’ adults might question some of them today.

Years later, in 2005, I visited Hampi in northern Karnataka, where lie the stunningly evocative ruins of Vijayanagar city, the capital of Vijayanagar Empire. Between its founding in c. 1336 and sacking in 1565, the city rose to become a great metropolis famed for its wealth, military prowess and cosmopolitanism, especially during the reign of Krishnadevaraya, a great military commander and patron of the arts and culture. For long stretches in this period, Vijayanagar Empire held nearly all of the land south of the Krishna River, ruling over about 25 million people (the subcontinent then had about 150 million).